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Browser banter with Opera co-founder

We chat with former CEO and Co-founder of Opera Software, Jon von Tetzchner about the future of the mobile, web standards and his latest brainchild – the Vivaldi web browser

Siddharth Parwatay
editor@digit.in



d Between the community-led model and the employee-led model of development, which approach has Vivaldi chosen and why?

Jon: We're using Chromium as the base for Vivaldi. A number of our users have found out that this is web code, and you can actually go in and edit it. This is because some of them believe that features are not being implemented fast enough so they go in and implement those features themselves. There are plenty of threads in our forums about people doing that.

I think if you look at most of the open source projects, they don't work the way you'd expect. Take Chromium for example. We may do a change to Chromium because we're using it and it would be very good for us if that change went into the core. But that doesn't happen. We could send it over to Google and Google might include it immediately because it was a critical bug fix. But if we propose a change that benefits us but doesn't benefit them in any shape or form, they wouldn't do it.

So we too are often faced with this question: *do you spend all your time getting in well-meaning bits of good code, but spending all your time trying to make sure it doesn't break anything? Or do you write the code yourself?* And we are in a way spending more time on the latter. That doesn't mean we don't value contributions. If someone wants a change and says "Guys, if you want



Jon von Tetzchner, founder Vivaldi Browser (former CEO, Opera Software)

to take my code, you can introduce it." that's always welcome. On the other hand, having a totally uncontrolled project has its drawbacks. We take the input but we make sure that those features that come in work really well together. So there really is a coherent thread to everything that we do. There is *one design* to our software. One design does not mean that there is only one correct way to do things, it just means that the way we adapt, it all works. I'm sure you've downloaded extensions that have messed stuff up. That's in a way what we avoid by taking the code and writing it ourselves and ensuring that it all works together. Most of the Chrome extensions work in Vivaldi still, and we spend a lot of time making sure that they do and that's important to us. Again, we work very closely with the end users because end users give us feedback, some of them actually do send us code that ends up being included, but in general this process of working, we would like to control that.

d Vivaldi has an android browser in the works right?

Jon: Yes, it's something that's coming.

Actually, when we started, we started with Android as a part of the equation. Unfortunately, we ran into some issues with how we were doing things and that's why it's taking a longer time. It will go into next year. Probably the latter half of next year.

d What kind of interesting features are you looking at incorporating in the mobile browser?

Jon: A lot of what we're doing will be about reusing as much code as possible, so you'll get a much more powerful browser. Typically, what we have today is we have limited mobile browsers. They're not the same as the desktop browser. I think we can do a browser with the capabilities of the desktop browser, but actually running on mobile. This then opens up all those opportunities that a full fledged browser would have included. And obviously we're not taking just any desktop browser, we're taking the most powerful desktop browser by far with regards to the capabilities it brings to the table. **d**

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